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TOMÁS MUNITA FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

In Afghanistan, a Rare Source of Joy
The sport of futsal has made national heroes of Alireza Ahmadi, 17, and others from the long-marginalized Hazara minority. Page A6.

An Economic Pitch So Familiar You May Recall Biden Saying It

For Trump, Selling Idea of ‘Golden Age’ Is Risky

By SHANE GOLDMACHER and REID J. EPSTEIN

President Trump is sounding a lot like President Joseph R. Biden Jr. these days, at least in one respect.

In a State of the Union address on Tuesday night that sought to reframe his first-year economic record before a midterm election that threatens to upend Republican majorities in Congress, Mr. Trump told a skeptical American public that the economy was doing great, despite what many may believe.

“Inflation is plummeting,” Mr. Trump declared on Tuesday. “Incomes are rising fast.”

Kenny Holston/The New York Times

The president after his State of the Union address on Tuesday.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Casting Democrats as Villains, Trump Produces a Spectacle

By KATIE ROGERS

WASHINGTON — It was spectacle as survival strategy.

In his State of the Union address, President Trump didn’t bother to introduce a raft of new policies — unusual in a midterm election year with control of Congress on the line. He did not seem concerned with making the case that he gets it when it comes to the issue Americans are most worried about. “Affordability,” he said, was part of a “dirty, rotten lie” perpetuated by the Democrats.

Instead, with the slashing style of a natural campaigner and the instincts of a onetime reality television producer, he spent the

better part of two hours baiting the ranks of incensed Democrats in the chamber and endeavoring to define them to the electorate as “sick,” unpatriotic and utterly out of step with the values of most Americans.

“These people are crazy, I’m telling you, they’re crazy,” Mr. Trump said, while relaying the story of a young person who he said had been forced to undergo

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FACT CHECK Job and crime trends that began before the president retook office continued. PAGE A12

As World Awaited Plan on Iran, Trump Gave Out Only Crumbs

By ANTON TROIANOVSKI

WASHINGTON — It took President Trump about 90 minutes in his State of the Union speech on Tuesday to get to Iran, the topic that much of the world was most eager to hear about.

When he did, Mr. Trump spent only three minutes talking about the country, largely repeating his vague talking points from recent days. By the time his most high-profile speech of the year was over, the president had done little to explain why he had amassed the largest amount of U.S. military firepower in the Middle East since the invasion of Iraq in 2003.

Iran is “again pursuing their sinister ambitions,” Mr. Trump said, asserting that Iran had resumed working toward building a nuclear weapon after the U.S.

bombing of its nuclear facilities in June.

“We are in negotiations with them. They want to make a deal,” the president said, restating his prior position without offering new details about what sort of deal he was seeking. “But we haven’t heard those secret words: ‘We will never have a nuclear weapon.’”

Iran has, in fact, often made that promise, even as evidence gathered over the years has shown that the country has repeatedly appeared to be testing the components that would go into a nuclear weapon. Abbas Araghchi, Iran’s foreign minister, said in a social media post before Mr. Trump’s speech that Iran “will under no

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Camp Mystic Once Bonded Families. Now Tragedy Opens a Rift.

By RUTH GRAHAM

DALLAS — Like many Texas women who spent their girlhood summers along a certain stretch of the Guadalupe River, Carla Smyrl cries these days when she talks about Camp Mystic.

“My whole life has been influenced by this place,” Ms. Smyrl said over a cup of tea in Dallas. “Once a Mystic girl, always a Mystic girl.”

Starting in 1976, she spent nine years as a camper and five as a counselor at the all-girls retreat, sent her three daughters to camp, and then worked for more than a decade as Mystic’s liaison to families in Austin, where she lives.

On July 4, 27 campers and counselors died in heavy flooding, along with the camp’s longtime executive director.

The disaster was shattering to Mystic’s thousands of alumnae, even if they hadn’t set foot there for decades. For many, the flood was a moment to draw on a tight network of lifelong relationships that has long been a core part of the Mystic mystique. Within the first hours and days, there were text chains, prayer services, old photos shared on private Facebook pages, and teary alumnae gatherings, including one at the George W. Bush Presidential Center in Dallas. (Laura Bush is a former Mystic counselor.)



MERIDITH KOHUT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Crosses for victims of the flooding outside Bubble Inn cabin at Camp Mystic girls’ summer camp.

It was a reminder that in Texas, camp is not just a way to while away the sticky hours of a Southern summer, but the foundation of an invisible network of status and power.

Going to Mystic places you in a “social web,” as one former counselor, Laura Beth Calvert, put it, that leads to the right college, the right sorority, the right husband, the right private preschool for your children, and then right back to Mystic.

But more than seven months after the flood, that social web is beginning to fray. In September, the camp’s longtime owners, the East-

land family, announced they would partly reopen this summer, a move vocally opposed by most of the parents of the victims, who have united under the name Heaven’s 27. Soon afterward, multiple Heaven’s 27 families filed

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Tariff Wins and Losses

Levies may have increased steel mill jobs but the added costs are crushing U.S. factories that use steel. PAGE B1

Paramount’s Bid Ups the Ante

Warner Bros. Discovery said the offer could lead to a “superior” deal than the one it agreed on with Netflix. PAGE B1

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Impact of War on Drugs

The U.S. has spilled blood and treasure to kill drug lords and defeat cartels, but the drugs keep coming. PAGE A4

New Leadership at the Louvre

Christophe Leribault, who runs the Palace of Versailles, takes over in the aftermath of a stunning heist. PAGE A10

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N.F.L.’s All In on Flag Football

The buzz around the sport — and the league’s investment in it — keeps growing, but there’s much to learn before the 2028 Summer Olympics. PAGE B7



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Women Shell Out for Art

Female collectors like Komal Shah are spending more than men are and influencing what museums acquire. PAGE C1

The Video-ifying of the Podcast

Netflix’s debut crop of offerings, including “The Pete Davidson Show,” revives debate on defining the medium. PAGE C1

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Other Victims in Guthrie Case

A fifth-grade teacher and his wife were terrified and hid out in their darkened bedroom when dozens of people who thought he was the kidnapper appeared on their suburban street. PAGE A21

Evading Vaccine Questions

Dr. Casey Means, the president’s pick for surgeon general and a supporter of Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., said “anti-vaccine rhetoric has never been part” of her message. PAGE A18

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Emily Oster PAGE A27



THURSDAY STYLES D1-8

Harsh Cure to Doomscrolling

If vowing to reduce screen time isn’t working, you can pay to block your physical access to your phone. “Brick” it with a device or an app. PAGE D1

